

Trump fund leaves ‘J6ers’ elated

Amid backlash over \$1.8-billion settlement, Capitol rioters clamor for a share of money.

By MICHAEL KUNZELMAN

WASHINGTON — David Johnston was a licensed attorney when he illegally entered the U.S. Capitol with a mob of President Trump’s supporters on Jan. 6, 2021. More than five years later, the South Carolina man is offering to help fellow “J6ers” apply for payouts from the Trump administration’s nearly \$1.8-billion fund for people claiming to be victims of a “weaponized” government.

He’ll do it for a 10% cut of any award, capped at \$5,000 apiece.

“I think the narrative is changing” about how the history of that day is being told, Johnston said in a video he posted to social media. “I think good things are happening for us.”

Hundreds of Trump loyalists pleaded guilty to storming the Capitol, admitting under oath that they broke the law. Some were convicted of sedition, and many attacked police officers while trying to overturn Trump’s election loss. Now pardoned by Trump, many hope to capitalize on their crimes by tapping into the \$1.776-billion settlement fund designed to compensate the president’s allies who claim they were politically prosecuted.

A bipartisan backlash to the fund and a legal roadblock have not dimmed the celebratory response from Jan. 6 rioters clamoring for a share of the taxpayer money. Some are staking claims even though the government has not established an application process and a judge has frozen the fund’s formation, at least temporarily.

The fund’s critics see it as another vehicle for Trump and his allies to whitewash the events of Jan. 6, retroactively justify the mob’s assault on a pillar of American

[See Settlement, A8]



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times



JONATHAN ALCORN For The Times



NOAH HAGGERTY Los Angeles Times

MAYOR KAREN BASS, top, speaks to supporters Sunday in Venice. Councilmember **Nithya Raman**, middle, visits a Korean restaurant in L.A. **Spencer Pratt**, above, talks to Erica Helon at a campaign event Saturday in Baldwin Village.

L.A. mayoral primary a fight to the finish

Top three — Raman, Bass and Pratt — are neck and neck for two spots in Tuesday race.

By DAVID ZAHNISER AND NOAH GOLDBERG

An embattled mayor. A brainy democratic socialist. A reality TV star who has been a staple on TMZ.

The top three candidates for Los Angeles mayor — incumbent Karen Bass, Councilmember Nithya Raman and Spencer Pratt of MTV’s “The Hills” — are fighting to secure an edge in Tuesday’s primary, capping one of the most unusual election seasons in city history.

L.A. voters have seen the arrival of AI campaign videos, an influx of dark money mailers and national media coverage from Us Weekly, Vanity Fair and many other outlets, thanks in large part to Pratt.

Raman is neck and neck with Bass, with Pratt close

on their heels, according to the most recent poll from the UC Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies, which was co-sponsored by The Times.

“I definitely think anyone has a shot,” said Parke Skelton, a Democratic political strategist who worked for Bass’ first mayoral campaign. “There’s two chairs and three contestants, and the music will stop and one will be without a chair.”

If none of the candidates wins a majority in Tuesday’s primary, the top two vote-getters will face off in the Nov. 3 general election.

Such a close contest would have been unthinkable two years ago. In 2024, Bass was riding high in the polls and an array of politicians, including Raman, relied on her endorsement for their own campaigns.

But Bass’ approval ratings nosedived after the Palisades fire, which destroyed thousands of homes and left 12 people dead.

Angry residents of Pa-

[See Mayor, A6]

FINAL PUSH: Bass, Raman and Pratt hold events over the weekend to shore up support. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Congress control may hinge on state

By KEVIN RECTOR

California’s decision to redraw its congressional map to flip as many as five House seats to Democrats in November is poised to play a big and potentially decisive role in the nation’s broader, bare-knuckle fight for control of Congress.

Tuesday’s primary races — where the top two candidates will advance to November runoff — won’t determine which Republicans are ousted in most cases, but they will provide an important first look at voter sentiment and bring the fall’s most crucial head-to-head contests into focus.

“There will be some real cues and signals about what to expect,” said Christian Grose, a redistricting scholar and political science pro-

fessor at USC. “We’re going to know how strong the Democrats’ chances are going to be based on who advances.”

As one example, Grose pointed to the redrawn 22nd Congressional District in the Central Valley, where incumbent Rep. David Valadao (R-Hanford) is facing challenges from moderate Assemblymember Jasmeet Kaur Bains (D-Delano) and progressive college professor Randy Villegas.

Grose said Bains is probably a stronger challenger than Villegas in a district that’s still a reach for Democrats — even if “either one could probably beat Valadao if 2026 is a big Democratic wave.”

Grose will also be closely watching the race between incumbent Reps. Young

[See Congress, A6]

Loss of fire prevention money looms

California leaders are urged to act as two sources of funding are poised to dwindle.

By NOAH HAGGERTY

With California facing increasingly destructive wildfires, experts and officials have long urged the strategic removal of dense, flammable vegetation that can erupt into particularly

destructive flames from a lightning bolt or the spark of a power line.

But after years of record investment by the state in such wildfire risk mitigation, two key money sources are drying up, potentially reducing the state’s annual budget for vegetation removal by hundreds of millions of dollars.

Wildfire resiliency advocates are warning that the loss of these funds will leave the state vulnerable to devastation and are calling on

California’s next governor to take that threat seriously.

Currently, California relies heavily on two funding sources for wildfire mitigation work: a state program that charges polluters for their emissions and a climate bond approved by voters in 2024.

Late Friday, however, state officials adopted a new structure for the emissions program, called cap-and-invest, that analysts say will probably reduce wildfire mitigation funding by

\$200 million per year. At the same time, the governor’s latest budget proposal puts the state on track to allocate the majority of the climate bond’s \$1.5 billion in wildfire prevention money within just three years.

As a result, California could go from routinely pulling more than \$600 million a year from these sources to just \$150 million, according to an estimate from the Wildfire Solutions Coalition — a group of more

[See Wildfires, A7]

Becerra’s rise spurs questions, theories

By DAKOTA SMITH AND NICOLE NIXON

Xavier Becerra’s campaign for California governor appeared doomed just two months ago. Every major opinion poll showed the longtime Democratic politician mired near the bottom of the pack, overshadowed by his flashier or wealthier rivals.

Now Becerra tops them all, according to the most recent opinion polls, emerging as a surprise front-runner in a race that has confounded voters and political experts alike.

Both his loyal supporters and well-financed critics have a hard time explaining

Becerra’s rapid ascent, with theories ranging from outright luck to a nefarious social media push. Others credit Becerra’s mild temperament, describing him as a steady figure — the Goldilocks candidate in a field of competitors who weren’t just right.

Becerra, when assessing his sudden rise, believes voters wanted experience, not “glitz and sizzle.”

“Folks put their faith in someone who’s done that kind of work and achieved results, someone who’s taken on real crises and been able to pull us out of them,” Becerra said in an interview Friday after a union rally in the Inland Empire. “Now it’s

[See Governor, A7]

The secret ingredient in Sudan’s civil war

Gum arabic goes into candy, makeup and hundreds of everyday items



FAIZ ABUBAKR For The Times

WORKERS in Sudan hold gum arabic, a vital ingredient that’s both reason and resource for the war.

By NABIH BULOS

OBEID, Sudan — Its illicit journey begins in the blood-soaked orchards of central Sudan before being spirited to ports across Africa and then to the U.S. and Europe.

By the time it ends up in products including M&Ms, medicines and makeup, few consumers or businesses know they’re contributing to the world’s worst humanitarian disaster.

Gum arabic, a resin that comes from the acacia tree, is as ubiquitous as it is

unglamorous, virtually unknown despite being a vital ingredient in hundreds of products. Its importance as a thickener and stabilizer — with no real substitute — should make it a boon for Sudan, once responsible for up to 80% of the world’s supply.

Instead, gum arabic, like so much of the country’s gargantuan wealth, now provides both the reason and resources for its staggeringly ruinous civil war.

That war, now in its fourth year with little sign of abating, has killed hundreds of thousands, displaced

[See Sudan, A3]

Wild mushroom threat escalates

As poisonings reach a record high, health officials warn residents not to eat such fungi. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

She found gold on and off the track

Transgender athlete AB Hernandez became a four-time state champ, all in the face of national backlash. **SPORTS, D1**

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 79/58. **B5**

The year of Catherine Opie

The L.A. photographer has a series of shows at home and abroad, and a lot to express. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

